

phi adajar

they/them

mit department of economics

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education

- 2021– PhD Candidate in Economics, MIT (expected June 2027)
Dissertation: “Essays on the Economics of Education”
- 2017–2021 SB in Mathematical Economics, MIT

research

- fields Education, Labor, IO, Development
- advisors Parag Pathak, Esther Duflo, Nikhil Agarwal

papers

- 1 (jmp) **The Winner’s Curse in Test-Blind Admissions**
with Nagisa Tadjfar and Kartik Vira.
- 2 **Identifying and Nurturing Math Talent: Evidence from Tamil Nadu**
with Esther Duflo, Glenn Ellison, Sara Fisher Ellison, and Harini Kannan.
Presented by coauthor at NBER Economics of Talent Meeting, Fall 2025; NBER Economics of Education Meeting, Spring 2026.
- 3 **A Practitioner’s Guide to Estimating School Effects in Centralized Assignment Systems**

in-progress

- 1 **From Cubs to Bears: The Evolution of Charter Effectiveness in Chicago**
- 2 **School-House Shocks: The Effect of Neighborhood-based School Assignment Policies on Intracity Migration**

affiliations

- 2022– Blueprint Labs, Research Associate

research assistantships

- 2022 Parag Pathak, MIT
- 2020 Benjamin Olken and Gabriel Kreindler, MIT + Harvard
- 2018–2021 Ernst Berndt and Rena Conti, MIT

undergraduate work

- 2021 [link](#) Evaluating Strategic Play: Manipulations with Symmetric Information in the Boston Mechanism
Thesis advised by Parag Pathak.
- 2021 [link](#) A Rising Tide for All or Wave for One? The Effect of Charter School Competition on District Achievement
Selected for MIT Undergraduate Journal of Economics, Vol. XX.
- 2019 [link](#) The Surprising Hybrid Pedigree of Measures of Diversity and Economic Concentration
with Ernst Berndt and Rena Conti. NBER Working Paper #26512.

teaching

- 2025 Kaufman Teaching Certificate, MIT Teaching + Learning Lab
- 2023 MIT 14.19 (UG Market Design), TA for Parag Pathak (rating 6.6/7)
- 2021 MIT 14.02 (UG Principles of Macroeconomics), TA for Ricardo Caballero (rating 6.5/7)
- 2019 MIT 14.27 (UG Economics and E-Commerce), TA for Sara Fisher Ellison (rating 5.8/7)

leadership + service

refereeing	<i>Econometrica, The Review of Economics and Statistics</i>
2025–	Graduate representative, MIT Committee on Undergraduate Admissions and Financial Aid
2022–	Graduate resident advisor, MIT Division of Student Life
2023	Graduate representative, MIT GRA Training Committee
2022–2023	Labor coffee organizer, MIT Department of Economics
2021–2024	Educational counselor (admissions interviewer), MIT Alumni Association
2020–2021	Undergraduate representative, MIT Committee on the Undergraduate Program
2020–	Alumni volunteer, National Science Bowl
2019–2021	Regional/invitational coordinator, invitational founder, MIT Science Bowl
2017–2021	Chair, program director, MIT Educational Studies Program

awards + fellowships

2025–2026	Jerry A. Hausman Dissertation Fellowship, MIT Department of Economics
2025–2026	NBER Doctoral Dissertation Fellowship, Global Math Talent
2021–2026	NSF Graduate Research Fellowship
2021	Phi Beta Kappa, MIT
2020	Burchard Scholar, MIT

grants

uk unraveling	
2023–2026	George and Obie Shultz Fund (\$64,500)
math talent	
2025, 2026	Carina Initiatives (\$4,300,000)
2024	Founders Pledge (£310,000)
2023, 2024	Agency Fund (\$600,000)
2023	J-PAL Science for Progress Initiative (\$72,000)

potpourri

music/theater	The Wedding Party (Secret City Adventures/Green Door Labs, 2026), Romancing Jan: Love and Labor (Incantrix Productions, 2026), Michael in “tick, tick... BOOM!” (2024), Kevin in “Remembering Her” (2023), Centrifuges Music Director (2022), Carnavale di Oscurità (upcoming)
puzzlehunts	Strategy captain for NES (4 th place MIT Mystery Hunt 2025, 2026), puzzle writer for Green Door Labs (Cthulhu Luau , Club Drosselmeyer), consultant for FableVision Studios (HMNH Puzzle Party)
crosswords	Daily NYT solving since 2022, perennial Boswords competitor, author for 2025 MIT Crossword Open
interests	D&D, trivia, jazz piano, baking, biking